

**Bob Aubrey 5-25-24 b. 1949 d. 3-8-24 service 5-25-24 at MVCC
Shared the homily with Rev. Rachel (Cooley) Shawler and Jim Ahrend**

Let's just be honest, Bob had a deep, personal, intense hate for chickens. He would order fried chicken when the staff would go to lunch, and tear into it like crazy, half-starved beast. Then, he sometimes laughed manically. One day at lunch, he shared with Jim Ahrend, and me, why chickens were on his private top-10 most wanted list.

Bob was born here in Albuquerque, to Paul and Shirley Spackeen in 1949. He and Monte Vista's own David Spackeen shared the same father. But their mother, Shirley had a wandering spirit about her. Over the years, she shared their lives with a variety of "new daddies" and a gypsy-esque lifestyle of never knowing where they would be living next.

Along the way, the crew found themselves living in Arkansas with their younger half-brothers Caitlin and Cash. Shirley and the "daddy du jour" decided to buy a mess of baby chickens in a money-making scheme "buy little – sell taller".

Unfortunately, it was not warm enough that winter to keep the giant box of baby birds outside. And the only heat in the house was a pot-belly stove in the middle of the living room. As you can already imagine, the birds figured out early on, how to climb out of the box. They continued to grow. They took over the house. They were in the boys' beds, nesting in their clothes, spreading their indiscretions all over everything. Bob hated those chickens. Even all grown up. Bob never forgot the chickens from hell.

Rachel's turn



Bob spent some time in high school living with his bio father until they had a falling out. Then he had a would-be mentor who supported him for a time, but ultimately did him wrong. He unfortunately had a number of adults in addition to his parents who let him down. But he found refuge with the Aubrey's, Jim & Donna, and their daughters Melissa, Jill, Tammy who he knew from church choir, and they adopted him and became supportive family.

Laurie's turn

Bob had a beautiful voice and after high school, enrolled at the University of New Mexico's theatre department. As luck would have it, there was a beautiful, witty, spirited young woman who was also involved in the theatre department. That semester, the university was auditioning for the leads to *Westside Story*. Bob and Shari had met before, but *not like* they would get to know each other as they were casted as Tony and Maria. As long as Bob was alive, Shari was always his Maria. Both of them loved life and loved being right. But no matter what, he loved everything about Shari.

He loved and respected her and in so many ways, she has been the glue of the family and of Bob.

Rachel's turn

What followed next was a period in the Army, as a helicopter mechanic in Korea and later time in the Army chorus, taking him & Shari to Spokane, WA and then Colorado Springs. In 1978, they returned to Albuquerque after Bob trained to transition into carpentry & they welcomed their first son, Lucas. In the 80's, Bob worked at a lumber yard & a shop specializing in hanging doors. They also welcomed their other two sons, Aaron & David. Bob continued to struggle with depression, though, and making sense of his early ^{life} ~~struggles~~. Abandonment wounds are deep, and I have to think he struggled to feel worthy and to know what was his to offer. As Laurie said, he would credit Shari as being a rock of the family especially during his deep struggles.

Shari was choir director at Monte Vista for most of the 80's and the family was always involved here. In

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the 90's at some point, a bit of a campaign began in the community urging Bob to serve as a counselor at ^{camp} camp, and he eventually tried it out. Many of us know that this was the beginning of something special, where Bob brought his many gifts in music, guitar plus stage presence to encourage all to sing; and his quick-witted, wry sense of humor, to emcee activities & bring laughter in so many skits. Bob was in it, modeling not taking yourself too seriously in the ridiculous games or "yuck night" activities like bowling with raw chickens on tarps greased with cooking oil: he could meet the moment and pour his life energy into the shared goal of fostering significant & faithful memories & relationships at camp. He could invite youth in with nurturing presence which wanted to hear all of their story, not just the pretty parts, and could say "I don't believe in that hierarchical, shaming God you've heard about either." And then show God's love through his

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attention and action, nurturing & inviting countless young people and co-leaders alike.

I have to think that Bob's struggles as a youth stirred his heart, and his disappointment at those mentors who failed him motivated him to show up in generous love, ~~both at camp & in youth ministry here at Monte Vista.~~ It seems he came to a sense of clarity, as if he heard Jesus's embodied, relational call to those fishermen with dirt under the nails & hurts in the hearts, "Follow me and I will make you fishers of people." What if the healing Jesus & his disciples do is really about calling ~~our~~ pain & suffering out of hiding, washing over the shame with love that says "I see you, inside all that," "I know because I'm inside all that too and to meet the real you & invite you in heals me ^{as well} ~~too~~..." "So let's shake it off, open our mouths wide with singing & fill our bellies with laughter. We'll clown around & keep that joke running till it becomes part of us, a memory

which pulls us toward truth. We'll ask the questions we think we're not supposed to, and even as we admit that we doubt like Thomas, this guy called Jesus may be a new friend, for he is fishing for truth alongside us, *& seeking to see & serve.*

Bob would insist again & again there is no one truth or one way, and that we must always make the table wider. He was endlessly curious about humans & their stories, and about Jesus's humanity & embodied love too. The final camp he directed that I attended, and I think the final high school

conference he ever did direct, had a theme inspired, *at least to Bob*

by the Chris Rice album "Smell the Color 9" ~~that Bob~~ *a favorite of his, saying that while there is mystery & vastness,*
~~loved: that relationship with Jesus was the point, that~~
~~the theme is~~ *is*
 relationships where we know God are the point. And

Bob would quote: "And that's my point exactly."

Laurie's Turn

Here is me again talking about his other ministry with Jim ending with this
 from Revelation:

Not that long after I came on board the staff of Monte Vista we lost our organist/choir director. Dr. Zink headed up the hiring committee. And we, much to our joy, now had, Jim Ahrend – musician extraordinaire on our staff. And our staff committees became bigger of what happens next Sunday, to Bob and Jim would dream of all the amazing things we could do to be church. It was a senior minister's dream come true. Soon Bob was involved in so much more than the youth and camping program. He decided to accept his call to ministry. The area was quick to recognize the legitimacy of his call, we now had Reverend Bob Aubrey. What a blessing. He had long been studying the latest theories of Biblical inquiry and current theological studies. Bob sought out people and groups in Albuquerque to explore all things new and old in religious studies. Talking to Bob's close friends, Bob and Bonnie Finch last night, Bob Finch said he and Bob would talk for our hours over definitions of God, and the very arrogance of our assuming we know the name of the Holy one. I know that there are a lot of you here today, who sometimes found yourselves in deep spiritual conversations with Bob. Between Bob and Jim, we found ourselves open to all kinds of experiential worships and community interactions. Eventually, all of this praying and dreaming created *Faith, Hope, and Jazz* as a way to bring more people the opportunity to meet Christ.

Jim's turn

Bob was absolutely – not perfect – but his life prepared him to be vulnerable to God's call. It opened him up to recognize ...

Then one of the elders addressed me, saying, 'Who are these, robed in white, and where have they come from?' ¹⁴I said to him, 'Sir, you are the

one that knows.' Then he said to me, 'These are they who have come out of the great ordeal; they have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb.

¹⁵ For this reason they are before the throne of God, and worship him day and night within his temple, and the one who is seated on the throne will shelter them.

¹⁶ They will hunger no more, and thirst no more; the sun will not strike them, nor any scorching heat;

¹⁷ for the Lamb at the center of the throne will be their shepherd, and he will guide them to springs of the water of life, and God will wipe away every tear from their eyes.'

Heaven's gain is our lost.